MODULE 3: Disinformation

Objective
To help participants understand:
- What disinformation is.
- How it is deliberately planned and spread.
- How it differs from misinformation.
- Its impact and how citizens can respond to it.

3.1 What Is Disinformation?
Disinformation refers to false or misleading information that is deliberately and systematically created and spread to achieve a specific purpose.
The key point is that disinformation is not an accidental mistake; it is a deliberate act.

In simple terms:
- Misinformation: False information shared unintentionally.
- Disinformation: False information created or shared intentionally.

Disinformation commonly aims to:
- Mislead people.
- Undermine trust.
- Influence decisions.
- Create divisions or tension.

3.2 Objectives and Motivations Behind Disinformation
Understanding why disinformation is created is essential.

Common objectives include:
- Spreading false narratives.
- Undermining trust in credible institutions.
- Creating social divisions.
- Influencing people's behaviour or decisions.

Such content is often designed to:
- Appear realistic.
- Present familiar language and images in a distorted way.
- Appeal to people's emotions.

3.3 Common Disinformation Tactics
Several familiar tactics are used to spread disinformation:

1. Entirely Fabricated Stories
Presenting an event that never happened as a true story.
2. False Names or Quotes
Circulating fabricated statements attributed to a person or institution.
3. Distortion of Information
Taking genuine information out of context to change its meaning.
4. Coordinated Sharing
Spreading the same content simultaneously across multiple pages, groups, and accounts.
5. Emotional Language
Using words that create fear, anger, hatred, or panic to push people into reacting quickly.

3.4 Misinformation vs. Disinformation

These two concepts are often confused, but understanding the distinction is essential.

Aspect	Misinformation	Disinformation
Intent	Unintentional	Intentional
Planning	Unplanned	Planned
Intended harm	No specific	Specific
Those sharing it	Ordinary individuals	Organised individuals or groups

An important point to remember:
Disinformation is often spread through misinformation when people unknowingly share content that was deliberately created to mislead.

3.5 Disinformation in the Bangladesh Context

Disinformation can be particularly harmful in societies such as Bangladesh because:

- False content spreads rapidly.
- People place considerable trust in social media.
- Opportunities to verify information are limited.

Disinformation commonly targets:

- Elections and electoral processes.
- Government decisions and policies.
- Civic rights and public services.
- Social peace and coexistence.

Disinformation is therefore more than an online problem; it can create real-world risks.

3.6 Impacts of Disinformation

At the Individual Level

- Poor decision-making.
- Confusion and psychological stress.
- A crisis of trust.

At the Social Level

- Division.
- Tension and conflict.
- A culture of rumours.

At the Democratic and Civic Level

- Declining voter confidence.
- Reluctance to fulfil civic responsibilities.
- Weakened trust in institutions.

3.7 How Disinformation Campaigns Operate

Disinformation campaigns generally follow a series of steps:

- **Message creation:** False or distorted information is prepared.
- **Target selection:** A particular group or section of the population is selected for influence.
- **Platform use:** The content is distributed through Facebook, YouTube, WhatsApp, and other platforms.
- **Rapid dissemination:** Multiple accounts share the content simultaneously.
- **Response monitoring:** Those behind the campaign observe which messages spread most widely.

This entire process is often planned and coordinated.